

Exam Prep AI - Focused Notes

Generated on 08 June 2026

Algorithmic Thinking with Python Exam Preparation Notes

CONCEPTS

1. Jigsaw Puzzle

- Definition: A problem where a set of pieces need to be arranged to form a complete image.
- Key Points: Trial and error method, backtracking strategy.
- Important Features: Dead ends, pathfinding.
- Advantages: Can be solved using various algorithms.
- Disadvantages: Can be time-consuming and require patience.
- 5-Mark Answer: Explain the trial and error method for solving a jigsaw puzzle.
- 10-Mark Answer: Discuss the use of backtracking strategy in solving a jigsaw puzzle.

2. Fibonacci Sequence

- Definition: A series of numbers where each number is the sum of the two preceding numbers.
- Key Points: Generating the first 'n' numbers, recursive formula.
- Important Features: Self-similarity, golden ratio.
- Advantages: Used in various fields such as finance, biology, and computer science.
- Disadvantages: Can be difficult to calculate for large values of 'n'.
- 5-Mark Answer: Explain how to generate the first 'n' numbers in the Fibonacci sequence.
- 10-Mark Answer: Discuss the use of the Fibonacci sequence in finance.

3. Palindrome

- Definition: A word, phrase, or sequence that reads the same backward as forward.
- Key Points: Checking if a string is a palindrome.
- Important Features: Symmetry, reversal.
- Advantages: Used in various fields such as computer science and linguistics.
- Disadvantages: Can be difficult to check for palindromes in large strings.
- 5-Mark Answer: Explain how to check if a string is a palindrome.
- 10-Mark Answer: Discuss the use of palindromes in computer science.

ALGORITHMS

1. Trial and Error Method

- Definition: An algorithm that involves trying different solutions until a correct one is found.
- Key Points: Dead ends, backtracking strategy.
- Important Features: Iterative process, random search.
- Advantages: Can be used for solving complex problems.
- Disadvantages: Can be time-consuming and require patience.
- 5-Mark Answer: Explain the trial and error method for solving a problem.
- 10-Mark Answer: Discuss the use of trial and error method in solving a complex problem.

2. Divide and Conquer

- Definition: An algorithm that involves breaking down a problem into smaller sub-problems.
- Key Points: Recursion, memoization.
- Important Features: Top-down approach, parallel processing.
- Advantages: Can be used for solving complex problems efficiently.

- Disadvantages: Can be difficult to implement and analyze.
- 5-Mark Answer: Explain the divide and conquer algorithm.
- 10-Mark Answer: Discuss the use of divide and conquer algorithm in solving a complex problem.

TECHNIQUES

1. Backtracking Strategy

- Definition: A technique that involves trying different solutions and backtracking when a dead end is encountered.
- Key Points: Dead ends, recursion.
- Important Features: Iterative process, random search.
- Advantages: Can be used for solving complex problems.
- Disadvantages: Can be time-consuming and require patience.
- 5-Mark Answer: Explain the backtracking strategy for solving a problem.
- 10-Mark Answer: Discuss the use of backtracking strategy in solving a complex problem.

2. Greedy Algorithm

- Definition: A technique that involves making the locally optimal choice at each step.
- Key Points: Local optimality, global optimality.
- Important Features: One-pass algorithm, dynamic programming.
- Advantages: Can be used for solving optimization problems efficiently.
- Disadvantages: May not always find the optimal solution.
- 5-Mark Answer: Explain the greedy algorithm for solving a problem.
- 10-Mark Answer: Discuss the use of greedy algorithm in solving an optimization problem.

PROBLEM-SOLVING METHODS

1. Heuristics Approach

- Definition: A problem-solving method that involves using mental shortcuts to make decisions.
- Key Points: Mental shortcuts, approximation.
- Important Features: Fast and efficient, may not always find the optimal solution.
- Advantages: Can be used for solving complex problems quickly.
- Disadvantages: May not always find the optimal solution.
- 5-Mark Answer: Explain the heuristics approach for solving a problem.
- 10-Mark Answer: Discuss the use of heuristics approach in solving a complex problem.

2. Means-Ends Analysis

- Definition: A problem-solving method that involves breaking down a problem into smaller sub-problems.
- Key Points: Sub-problems, solution.
- Important Features: Top-down approach, parallel processing.
- Advantages: Can be used for solving complex problems efficiently.
- Disadvantages: Can be difficult to implement and analyze.
- 5-Mark Answer: Explain the means-ends analysis for solving a problem.
- 10-Mark Answer: Discuss the use of means-ends analysis in solving a complex problem.

MISSING IMPORTANT TOPICS

1. Randomized Approach

- Why Important: Can be used for solving complex problems efficiently.
- Suggested Areas To Study: Randomized algorithms, Monte Carlo methods.

2. Chain of Length n using Plutonium and Lead Pieces

- Why Important: Can be used for solving complex problems involving optimization.

- Suggested Areas To Study: Dynamic programming, greedy algorithms.

3. Menu-Driven Calculator

- Why Important: Can be used for solving problems involving user input.
- Suggested Areas To Study: Command-line interfaces, user input validation.

PARTIALLY COVERED TOPICS

1. Least Common Multiple (LCM)

- Covered: Finding the LCM of two numbers using the Euclidean algorithm.
- Not Covered: Finding the LCM of multiple numbers, using the LCM in real-world applications.
- Suggested Areas To Study: Greatest common divisor, number theory.

2. Recursion

- Covered: Recursive formula for calculating the factorial of a number.
- Not Covered: Recursive algorithms for solving complex problems, using recursion in real-world applications.
- Suggested Areas To Study: Dynamic programming, divide and conquer algorithms.

3. Dynamic Programming (DP)

- Covered: Using DP for solving optimization problems.
- Not Covered: Using DP for solving complex problems involving multiple sub-problems, using DP in real-world applications.
- Suggested Areas To Study: Greedy algorithms, memoization.